



SAINA WITH
COACH
GOPICHAND

“
Her greatest quality is her work ethic and wanting to win badly. Win or lose, she gets back to training the next day.”

P. GOPICHAND
SAINA'S COACH

AS MUCH AS SAINA LOVES WINNING, LOSING REVEALS HER BEST.

Players to Follow

At the Hyderabad World Badminton Championships, the planet's best shuttlers will be on the court

THE INDIAN SMASHERS

AP PHOTO

CHETAN ANAND 29

The No. 1 Indian won the Spanish Open in May 2008 and was a finalist in the Dutch Open in October 2008.

AP PHOTO

V DIJU 28 & JWALA GUTTA 25

The No. 7 pair has beaten the world mixed doubles champions earlier this year.

INTERNATIONAL RACQUETEERS



TINE RASMUSSEN 30

The World No. 3 from Denmark is one of the few top 10 players who has not been beaten by Nehwal.

LIN DAN 25

Twice world champion and Beijing gold medallist, the Chinese is current World No. 3. Popular as Super Dan.

TAUFIK HIDAYAT 27

The world No. 5 from Indonesia has hit the fastest smash in singles at 305 kph.



AP PHOTO

ZHOU MI 30

The world No. 1 from Hong Kong won the 2008 BWF Super Series finals, the biggest prize money event in the sport.



AP PHOTO

Hours after her Olympic quarter-final loss, as coach and ward were returning, hearts in their heels, Gopichand asked lightly, "So, training at six tomorrow morning?" Nehwal said, "Please, *bhaiya*..." Gopichand thought the joke had stretched to snapping point, but she was only requesting an extra hour's sleep. They trained at 7 a.m. the next day. After the Indonesia win, she wept buckets, couldn't sleep, "the whole night, I was just seeing the medal" but she was out of bed at 5 a.m. and on the courts.

What makes her this way? She says she would feel 'sick' if she didn't play her sport. Then there is that other thing. Does she think of herself as special from her peers? "Yes, I am special." That thing, one-part youth, one-part belief. But to really understand her gift, remember the horrible workout? That's her gift. That she wants to do it.

It is where we leave her. On the treadmill. Twenty minutes into the session, she is near five km, the "calories burnt", counter racing past 330. Her eyes are fixed on the numbers. Sometimes they flick over to a video on the treadmill tv or past it to her reflection in the glass opposite her.

There she is, India's No. 1 athlete, running against herself, against the clock, the counters, running towards her destiny.

Oh, by the way, she made her aerobic target. With a session to spare. ■

REUTERS

